



SIPRA DAS

Reaping a Political Harvest

BANGALORE Karnataka may be on the verge of drought, but that hasn't deterred Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa from deciding to lead a delegation of ministers and MLAs to a Kannada conference in Chicago later this month. Travel and stay costs are pegged at around Rs 50 lakh, which

will go from the taxpayers' pockets. But some ministers differ. B. Sriramulu, also a mining baron, says he will pay for himself and his colleagues so that the Government is not burdened. Officially, the trip is meant to seek new investment from NRIs.

Yeddyurappa is also readying a largesse for

EYEING DIVIDENDS: Yeddyurappa

nearly 1,000 farmers in the state. They will visit China in batches of over a dozen to get a first-hand account of the agricultural sector there, and Rs 10 crore has been earmarked for the China visits.

The state Agricultural Department is now planning more "study tours" to countries like Denmark, Brazil, Israel, the Netherlands, Madagascar, Ethiopia and Indonesia.

"There's no harm in helping our people learn new techniques, and if this study tour can help us, then why not go ahead with it," says Yeddyurappa. This is one sure shot technique of a political kind from which Yeddyurappa is hoping to reap rich dividends during the polls.

by Stephen David

Winning Spree

DELHI It was just another milestone in the incredible journey of India's most popular television channel when Aaj Tak won the Best Hindi News Channel award. Aroon Purie, CMD of TV Today Network, part of the India Today Group, received the Lifetime Achievement Award for his contribution to TV news. Aaj Tak has also



Aaj Tak's Abhisar Sharma (right) with the NT Award

won awards in three other categories: the best auto show in Hindi (*Chakke Pe Chakka*), the best investigative programme in Hindi (*Operation Kalank*) and the best promo for a news show (*Aap Ka Budget*). Earlier this year, Aaj Tak had won the top prize at the Indian Telly Awards, Indian Television Academy Awards and the Sansui Television Awards.

"News is my passion and I am delighted to win the NT Awards. Aaj Tak continues to set the agenda in the news space and is the most trusted news brand," Purie said. "Winning yet another Best News Channel Award reflects Aaj Tak's leadership and the faith that viewers and the industry have in us," said G. Krishnan, CEO of TV Today. The NT Awards is part of the News Television summit, organised by IndianTelevision.com. ■

Learning On

LUCKNOW With its recently launched 'Angrezi Seekho' programme, the state Government is bent on teaching English to the have-not children and help them join the economic mainstream with confidence. Launched by the Basic Education Department and Lucknow District Institute of Education and Training (DIET) through Learn English Through Radio, it covers students of Class IV and VI in 1,800 schools.

UNICEF was toying with the idea of helping children in rural as well as urban areas to learn English. However, it found that most teachers in the state lack in English pro-

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



RADIO GA GA: A transistor school in session

nunciation and in meanings of words. UNICEF and DIET officials convinced AIR to allot 15 minutes of its morning hour's prime time from 9.45 a.m. thrice a week. Its target is students, housewives and school dropouts. DIET also trained one teacher each

from the 1,800 schools and equipped all the institutions with transistor radios. A far cry from Mulayam Singh Yadav's 'Angrezi Hatao' campaigns that proclaimed that English is the "language of destruction".

by Farzand Ahmed